

*They send you the long way to the komturia, through streets that have already turned, and you keep your heads down and your ears open the way couriers learn to. What you catch does not sit easy. A draper on his step, to no one: that the Order taxes its own merchants to the bone and lets its favourites trade free – a lord that fleeces the very people it claims to keep. Two watermen, lower: that the brothers were a thousand once and are barely three hundred now, a garrison of greybeards behind a wall that can scarcely hold its own gate. An old woman, plainly, as you pass: that the towns begged the Emperor in Vienna for justice and the Order went on doing as it pleased – so what is such a master good for? None of them know whose letters you carry tonight. You are not certain, just now, that you would want them to.*

*The komturia kitchen is loud with the day's work – knives and copper and the heat of the ovens – and beyond its walls a city that will not settle. The brother who keeps the kitchen you do not see; there is no hand to spare tonight. But the spice jars stand waiting in a row, bare of any label, and propped against them a note in a careful, cloister-trained hand.*

Brothers – the komtur's table will not touch what the kitchen cannot name, and these came up from a merchant's store with never a mark on them. I've no hour free tonight. But you are of our own, and this is our own craft – German work, that has flourished in these lands as long as the Order has held them; any man of ours knows these roots by heart. Take their measure however you can, only do not open them – a spice once aired is spoiled. And keep to the rule: it names every root and meal a piernik takes, yet not all of them stand here tonight – you will have more names than jars, so set each jar to its name and let the rest be.

Let the town shout itself hoarse beyond these walls. The komtur dines as he has always dined, and this kitchen does not falter. See that you do not either.

– Brother of the komtur's kitchen

*The brother's pride is a warm thing to stand in — surer than the cold talk in the streets, and you let it warm you, and try not to weigh which of the two is telling you the truth. You serve the Order's cause tonight; or so the letter in your bag says. And here is a small service it asks of you. Seven jars, and no two alike — if your senses are keen enough to part them. Trust what they tell you, and set the right name to each letter on his card. His recipe names every ingredient a PIERNIK takes; only some of them stand here in the jars, so a few names will have no jar at all — the recipe is your guide to what to expect.*

↪ GAME MASTER — Bring the filled card to the Game Master, who keeps to the Rynek Staromiejski (the Old Town market square). If the master judges the pierniki worthy, you'll have your meal — and your next orders.